The Hunted Queen

Queen Kalia of Bragod was married for her beauty, but has become an unexpected champion of the common people. This has made her many enemies in the court, and some whisper that the king is among them. As she returns from a distant voyage, she learns that her life may be in danger. Can you protect the queen from certain doom?

This is a short D&D adventure for 4-7 characters of 3rd level. 🔗 https://bit.ly/331LLCw • Payton Swick © 2020 CC Attribution: http://bit.ly/cc-by-4

Introduction

The PCs are bodyguards, servants, or companions of **Queen Kalia**, a charismatic woman in her 30s. The party and a troop of soldiers are traveling from a diplomatic visit to a city in the far north back to the castle of Veygandburg in a carriage. Heavy snow makes the ride a slow one. The queen rides inside the carriage alongside her **uncle Yasgir** and his 5-year-old **son Dunc**. (Unknown to any, Dunc has been killed and replaced by a **doppelganger** paid to kill the queen.)

The queen worries for the people who rely on her. She envies the PCs for their autonomy, unbound by the duties and obligations that weigh upon her.

Queen Kalia suddenly remembers that before they departed, she had received a package from the **royal mage, Lady Ampheryn**. Everyone knows that Ampheryn cares deeply for the queen and has risked much to aid her in the past. The queen opens the package, displaying a glowing crystal and a letter sealed with the symbol of a **white crane**.

The letter

"My queen, events have unfolded quickly during your absence. Letters have appeared that allegedly prove your connection to rebel groups. Several of the council now speak openly against you. Guard yourself well on your return. If you should need help, speak the words 'Abb aép straede va' while holding this crystal. It will open a portal to the nearest waypoint I myself have prepared. Each waypoint houses a similar crystal, hidden for safety but marked by my sign. The final portal will bring you to my tower. I pray that you shall not need them. Loyally, Ampheryn."

Scene 1: The ambush

Just then the carriage stops as terrifying spider-like monsters cut through the soldiers. About 50 feet / 15 meters distant stands a hooded assassin bearing the tattoo of a viper on the side of his face, marking him as a member of the Snakes Errant, a deadly school of evil mages. The assassin is content to let his creatures do the work and will not engage.

The soldiers do not stand a chance, and neither do the PCs. If one of them does not use the crystal, the queen will do so. If anyone is trapped by the spiders, one of the soldiers will sacrifice themselves to allow the PCs to escape.

Upon speaking the magic words, the crystal shatters and its shards recombine to form a magic portal that each person can jump through to take them to the first waypoint.

Scene 2: The desert oasis

The first waypoint is a hot desert sand dune, just uphill from a large grove of palm trees surrounding a village and a small lake on which floats several wooden rafts, anchored to the bottom by ropes. The villagers are elves, distrustful of outsiders, and do not speak Common, so communicating with them may be difficult.

As they explore, or if they introduce themselves, a **mad old man** will thrust himself forward accusing the queen of being a doppelganger. He will attempt to stab the queen with a silver dagger by way of proof, as silver harms such creatures. If the PCs do not take the dagger, the queen will.

Eventually the party will hear screams from the other side of the village where the assassin and his monsters have teleported. **Two of the blade spiders** have moved quickly and will attack the party immediately while the assassin and his other pets slowly advance through the fleeing elves. If needed, the assassin can magically raise stone from below the lake to create a bridge.

A DC 12 Arcana check will reveal that it should be impossible to track the Queen through a portal, unless they are carrying something marked by the assassin (it is in fact Dunc who is guiding the assassin to their location).

Anyone who examines the rafts from a distance will see a white crane perched on one: this is Ampheryn's symbol. At the end of the rope on that raft is a small chest containing the second crystal and a **potion of Greater Healing** (4d4+4). Activating that crystal will open a portal to the second waypoint.

Scene 3: The border town

The second waypoint is an alley in the bustling border town of Turingrad which is well known for its colorful markets. People of many different nations and cultures vie for customers in its narrow stone streets.

As the party navigates the crowded streets, they may spot the hanging flag of *The Crane's Gifts*, a market stall selling jewelry surrounded by mercenary guards. The stall's flag matches Ampheryn's symbol, and indeed on a high shelf behind the counter sits the glowing crystal behind the thick bars of a locked iron case.

The merchant that owns the stall is the shrewd and greedy **Madame Rugg**. She does not want to sell the crystal as she uses it to attract customers. However, she is willing to sell it for the right price. It's also possible to trick her, coerce her, or steal the crystal from its shelf. The stall also sells 2 **potions of Greater Healing** (4d4 + 4).

Eventually shrieks from the street will announce the arrival of the assassin and his creatures. As they get closer, Rugg will quickly pack up her belongings and flee. **Rugg's guards** are loyal only to money, but they may be bribed to help.

When activated, the crystal will open a portal to the mage's tower.

Scene 4: The mage's tower

The final portal brings the party to the roof of the royal mage's tower. The roof is a 60-foot / 18 meter wide stone disc on which thick oak trees have magically grown, giving the appearance of a forest in the sky. Lightning flashes in the dark clouds above, and occasionally will strike a **tall metal pillar** that stands at the center. There are no obvious exits, other than the long drop to the ground below. This time the assassin and his blade spiders will teleport in immediately after the PCs, but Ampheryn will also appear.

During the fight, the doppelganger will try to stealthily kill Queen Kalia in the confusion.

Any creature within 10 feet / 3 meters of the central pillar at initiative 20 when the lighting strikes must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 7 (2d6) lightning damage.

Ampheryn

Armor Class 15 (mage armor)
Hit Points 40 (9d8)
Speed 30 ft. / 10 m.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	8 (-1)	20 (+5)	16 (+3)	13 (+2)

Shield other. As a reaction when one creature within 10 ft. of Ampheryn would take damage, the creature takes half instead and Ampheryn takes half.

Actions

Stop. One creature within 10 ft. must succeed on a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw or be paralyzed for 1 minute. The creature may repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns. Can only affect one creature at a time.

Fire bolt. *Ranged Spell Attack:* +8 to hit, range 30 ft., one target. *Hit* 8 (1d6 + 5) fire damage.

Perfect aim. (Bonus action) The next attack made by one ally within 30 ft. gains advantage.

Doppelganger

AC 11; **HP** 20 (2d8 + 10); **Speed** 30 ft. / 10 m.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)

Weaknesses. Silver deals double damage.

Actions

Stab. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, range 5 ft., one target. *Hit* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

Giant Blade Spider

Medium beast, unaligned

Armor Class 13
Hit Points 20 (4d8 + 2)
Speed 40 ft. / 12 m., climb 40 ft. / 12 m.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	4 (-3)

Actions

Stab. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5ft., one target. *Hit* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Pounce. The spider jumps 15 feet and can land in another creature's space. That creature must succeed on a DC 12 Strength or Dexterity saving throw or be knocked prone and take 3 (1d6) slashing damage.

Snake's Errant Assassin

Medium humanoid, lawful evil

Armor Class 15 (studded leather)
Hit Points 40 (9d8)
Speed 30 ft. / 10 m.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	8 (-1)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	8 (-1)

Magic resistance. The assassin has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

Magical parry. As a reaction when he would be hit by an attack, the assassin adds 3 to his AC.

Actions

Shadow dagger. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5ft., one target. *Hit* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage and the target must make a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) necrotic damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a success.

Shadow bolt. *Ranged Spell Attack:* +6 to hit, range 30 ft., one target. *Hit* 6 (1d6 + 3) necrotic damage.

Sculpt earth. The assassin touches an area no larger than 10 ft. on a side and can reshape dirt, sand, stone, or clay in the area. He can raise or lower elevation, erect a wall, or form a pillar. The changes move too slowly to cause damage.

Blindness. One creature within 30 ft. must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or become blinded for 1 minute. At the end of each of their turns, the target may repeat the saving throw, ending the effect on a success.